TRIALS AND TRIBULATIONS

For SRK, the return has taken a while—1,484 days, to be precise. In between, the failure of a spate of films, including *Fan* (2016), *Jab Harry Met Sejal* (2017) and *Zero* (2019), to live up to the lofty box office expectations of an SRK-starrer led to some soul-searching. His choice of scripts and ability to draw the crowds began to get questioned. As Khan took 2019 off to recalibrate, he had no theatrical release for the first time since his debut in 1992. The Covid-19 pandemic extended his break. However, the bigger adversity was to come not in his career but in his personal life.

In October 2021, the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) arrested Aryan Khan, the eldest of his three children, outside a cruise ship on charges of consumption, sale and possession of drugs. Aryan, just shy of 25, spent 22 days in jail as his father convened a battery of the country's best lawyers to secure his bail. Seven months later, the NCB dropped the charges.

The damage, though, was done. Even as a large section of the Hindi film industry rallied behind Khan, sections of the media and keyboard warriors mobilised to attack him. One of the most media-savvy celebrities, Khan had refrained from issuing any statement during or after his ordeal. The silence did not stop the attacks. Shoots of two of his films, *Pathaan* and *Jawan*, were disrupted. In those times, Khan is said to have often sought refuge in a bathroom, a sanctuary, his dear ones say, where he could weep in peace.

are the five films that have added to the Khan legend



OM SHANTI OM (2007)

Farah Khan puts together the most enjoyable tropes of '70s cinema—reincarnation, revenge, et al.—to weave an engaging romantic tale produced by Khan's banner



CHENNAI EXPRESS (2013)

This Rohit Shetty-directed action comedy gives Khan's image as Rahul a delightful spin. It is the first SRK film to breach the Rs 200 crore mark and was his biggest hit until *Pathaan*

This time, though, they must be tears of joy. "*Main woh chaar saal bhool gaya hoon pichhle chaar din ke andar* (The last four days have made me forget the last four years)," he says. Few would have anticipated *Pathaan* would shatter so many records, especially given the events that transpired months before its release. Khan had to intervene personally, making calls to a few chief ministers to ensure his film had a smooth release, after a few politicians in the ruling party took offence to the saffron shade of his co-star Deepika Padukone's swimwear in the track "*Besharam Rang*". "Anybody who has faced so much in life, in the past or recently, has to be a strong person," says Rajkumar Hirani, who is currently working with Khan in the December release, *Dunki*. "Anybody under that kind of pressure will bog down. You have to be a fighter, survivor, mentally strong and extremely intelligent to be able to deal with this."

And deal with it he did, even though Khan said the past two months were especially "stressful". Karan Johar gives a brief glimpse of the man in his autobiography, *An Unsuitable Boy*, which perhaps can help us understand the man behind the icon.

"I think when he hurts," Johar writes of Khan, "he becomes quiet." That quietness, however, is not to be confused with capitulation, rather it is a time for Khan to gather himself. And his absence from the big screen didn't mean he was not working. When the pandemic interrupted film schedules, Khan learned how to cook Italian food. Pathaan's cast and crew were treated to pizzas made by him while shooting in Mumbai. Khan also used his free time to be with his three children—Aryan, Suhana and AbRam. "There is no reason for my life except my children," he had told INDIA TODAY magazine in 2016 while promoting *Fan*. "I need to push them and make something nice out of them and my films." He has been content with his and Gauri's parenting. At the Sharjah International Book Fair in November 2022, when asked what achievement his parents would be most proud of, Khan said they'd be "happy" with the way he has brought up his children.

SHAH RUKH THE MAN

"I am very proud to say I get scared sometimes, I feel sad sometimes, I lose confidence many times in a day," Khan said at the only publicity event for *Pathaan*. But amid the lows, he is mindful of the hundreds who stand outside his house daily, with a *mannat* just to get a glimpse of their idol. "They love me absolutely...it is selfless and beautiful," he said